

Roman coinage notes

Early republic

- When the denarius (silver penny) was first introduced around 211BC it was designated to be worth 10 copper asses (the Latin name for the Greek assarion) (1/10 assarion = 1 denarius).
- The Latin *deni* means “containing ten”.

Retariffing of 141 BC

- To account for the decreasing value of the copper used in the assarion, they changed the value of a denarius to be 16 as (1/16 assarion = 1 denarius).

In “modern” coin systems we typically only have one base coin that represents “the smallest thing you can buy something with” (eg. our penny). However, the Roman coin system was a little different.

The Assarion (the “working” coin)	Main coin for daily staples like the sparrows. Standard unit for marketplace transactions.
The Kodrantes (the “legal” minimum)	The Roman <i>quadrans</i> . Often used to pay for very cheap, state-regulated services (eg. entrance fee for a public bath). Its value was $\frac{1}{4}$ assarion.
The Mite (the “local” coin)	The <i>lepton</i> was a Jewish coin. Its value was $\frac{1}{2}$ of the Kodrantes (1/8 assarion, 1/128 denarius).

This was also part of why moneychangers existed (currency exchange): [Mat 21:12](#), [Mat 25:27](#), [Mar 11:15](#), [Joh 2:14,15](#). Roman coins were considered idolatrous and their use was strictly forbidden at the temple. So, while you earned your wages in Roman penny/pence per day (denarius G1220), you would need to exchange that for the silver temple shekel for example for the yearly temple tax ($\frac{1}{2}$ shekel per person, per year except during [Nehemiah 10:32](#)’s time; the yearly temple tax **is not** a commandment in the Law; Being Son of the King, Jesus was exempt from paying such a tax regardless of it’s origin. It appears that He paid it anyway to avoid offending them but where did the money really come from? [Matthew 17:24-27](#)).

Matthew 10:29 Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing ? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father.	G787 (assarion) as (1/16 denarius)
Luke 12:6 Are not five sparrows sold for two farthings , and not one of them is forgotten before God?	G787 (assarion) as (1/16 denarius)
Matthew 5:26 Verily I say unto thee, Thou shalt by no means come out thence, till thou hast paid the uttermost farthing .	G2835 (Kodrantes) quadran (1/64 denarius)
Mark 12:42 And there came a certain poor widow, and she threw in two mites , which make a farthing .	G2835 (Kodrantes) quadran (1/64 denarius)

[Matthew 10:29](#) and [Luke 12:6](#) might seem like they are describing a different value farthing but they both use the same exact coin (the assarion). Therefore, instead of being two different ratios for the same coin it is more likely that the merchant offered a bulk discount by including an extra sparrow for free. Ignoring bulk discounts, one could purchase 32 sparrows for 1 Roman silver penny (1 denarius).

1 Denarius (penny/pence)	16 Assarion (Mat 10/Luk 12 farthing)
1 As	4 Quadrans (Mar 12/Mat 5 farthing)
1 Quadran (kodrantes)	2 Lepta (mites)

Coin Name	Typical Use / Purpose	Metal	Value vs. Denarius	Qty per Denarius
Aureus (English Dram; Hebrew Adarkon/Darkemon; Persian Daric)	Mat 10:9 ; ~8.4g; state-level wealth, international trade, temple treasures; An English dram is 1/8 of an ounce ~3.88g.	Gold	25x	1/25
(Tyiran) Shekel (94%+ silver purity)	Temple Tax (for 2 people): The only silver accepted in the Temple. Matthew 17:27 " <i>for me and thee</i> " (1 stater/statera = 2 didrachmae = 1 Shekel)	Silver	4x	1/4
Bekah	Temple Tax (for 1 person): The annual "tribute" per male (Exo 38:26).	Silver	2x	1/2
Denarius (~80% silver purity) (Penny; Latin)	Standard Day's Wage: Payment for a laborer or soldier (Mat 20:2 a penny = a denarius).	Silver	1	1
Drachma (Greece)	Mat 20:2 (Denarius), Luke 15:8 (drachma)	Silver	1	1
Assarion (Farthing)	Small Grocery Purchase: Bought two sparrows in the market (Mat 10:29).	Copper	1/16	16
Kodrantes (Farthing)	State Fees: Admission to public baths or very minor civil fines (Mat 5:26 kodrantes/quadran; 1/64th denarius).	Bronze	1/64	64
Prutah	Common Market Change: The standard "pocket change" for Judeans. (Mishnah Kiddushin 1:1; 1 perutah/prutah = 1/8 issar (assarion) = 1/128 denarius)	Bronze	1/64	64
Lepton (Mite)	The "Widow's Offering" (Mar 12:42).	Bronze	1/128	128

When one went to the temple to purchase an animal to sacrifice it was a multi-step, costly, monopolistic system to navigate which severely reduced purchasing power and brought in substantial money for the exchangers, inspectors, and animal peddlers for very little effort:

1. They had to first exchange their currency to the more (silver) pure “Tyrian Shekel” (temple shekel).
 - The moneychangers charged a fee (Kolbon) of ~5-10% (~½ to 1 days wage).
2. If you brought your own animal sacrifice there was an inspection fee charged to see if the animal had any blemishes.
 - If your animal failed the inspection you had to purchase one from the sellers at the temple who were often the same people performing the inspections.
 - Animals that were pre-screened (inspected) to be guaranteed blemish-free demanded a substantial markup from normal market values.
 - The mark-up prices ranged anywhere from 50%-160% (oxen) to 300-1500% (doves).
 - Notice that the markup prices especially took advantage of the desperate poor (Leviticus 5:7, 12:8, 14:21-22).

Sacrifice	Rural Market Price (Pence/Denarii)	Temple "Certified" Price	Estimated Markup (%)	Laborer's Wage Equivalent
Pair of Doves	~0.25 (1/4 Penny)	1 – 4 Pence	300% – 1500%	1 to 4 Days of Labor
Lamb / Kid	4 – 8 Pence	10 – 40 Pence	150% – 400%	2 Weeks to 1.5 Months
Ram	12 – 15 Pence	30 – 80 Pence	150% – 430%	1 to 3 Months
Young Bullock	40 – 60 Pence	75 – 200 Pence	85% – 230%	3 to 7 Months
Full Ox	100 – 150 Pence	150 – 400+ Pence	50% – 160%	6 Months to 1+ Year